

# Pluto

Pluto, a ball of ice and rock, was discovered in 1930, and became our solar system's ninth planet. However, in 2006 it was reclassified as a dwarf planet.

## Why isn't it a planet?

Pluto was reclassified as it is just one of many objects in what is known as the Kuiper Belt. Two of the other named dwarf planets in our solar system are Ceres and Eris.



The Kuiper Belt is a band of comet-like objects that orbit the Sun beyond Neptune.

## A frozen world

At times, the surface of Pluto has an atmosphere. It appears when Pluto is closer to the Sun and its ice is warmed to release gas, but it refreezes and disappears when Pluto moves farther away from the Sun.

## So how big is Pluto?

Pluto is estimated to be about 2,370 km (1,473 miles) across, and Eris is a similar size. Even some of the solar system's moons are larger than Pluto, including our moon!

